

Where Hard Surfaces Meet the House

Driveways, walks and patios. The exam asks about the joint, the crack width, and the trip hazard.

Concrete and asphalt move independently of the building, so wherever a hard surface meets the house there is a joint that will open. Water finds an open joint immediately, and it runs straight down beside the foundation.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 4 TIMES

When a driveway or walk runs up against a foundation wall:

Some type of caulking is recommended.

Caulk that seam whatever the slope does. You have missed this four times, and the reason it is easy to miss is that caulking normally signals a temporary repair. Here it is the correct recommendation, because the joint is designed to move and a flexible sealant is the right way to close a moving joint.

The two widths you report

The numbers here

Concrete driveway crack — reportable at	1/4 in wide
Sidewalk or walkway offset — a trip hazard at	3/8 in

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS

Cracks in a concrete driveway:

Should be reported if they are one-quarter inch or wider.

Below a quarter inch, a driveway crack is ordinary shrinkage. Note the pair: a quarter inch is about width, three-eighths is about a vertical offset between two slabs, which is what actually catches a toe.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS

The main problem associated with the edge of a patio that does not properly meet the surrounding vegetation is that it:

Causes a trip hazard.

The temptation is to answer with water or with plant damage. The answer is the person walking on it. Where a question describes an edge, a lip or a level change on a walking surface, safety comes before moisture.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. A walk runs up against the foundation wall. What do you recommend?
2. Why is caulk the right answer here when it is usually a temporary repair?
3. At what width is a driveway crack reportable?
4. At what offset does a sidewalk become a trip hazard?
5. A patio edge meets the planting badly. What is the main problem?